THE TRENDSETTERS



THE BOLD TYPE
(Netflix)

Three women working in a magazine struggle to strike a balance between their professional and personal lives

SEX EDUCATION
(Netflix)

From asexuality to pansexuality, this popular British series delights even as it entertains. It's even got a cool sex therapist doling out advice





THE SEX LIVES OF COLLEGE GIRLS
[Amazon Prime Video]

Following four freshwomen from different socio-economic backgrounds, the Mindy Kaling show talks about body positivity and pleasure

SEX AND THE CITY
[Disney+ Hotstar]

Among the first shows to put the desires of women front and centre, it inspired a range of fun shows about female friendship



had higher contribution and representation of women, both on and off screen, and also scored much better on the Bechdel test (a yardstick on gender representation in content) compared to theatrical releases. Aparna Purohit, head of India originals, Amazon Prime Video, says OTT platforms "opened the door for more inclusive storytelling that provides greater opportunities to women. Streaming has given voice to more female storytellers, resulting in an increase in stories driven by female characters with agency".

Devika Bhagat, one half of the writing duo of the Amazon Prime series *Four More Shots Please!*, is making the most of the opportunity. When etching the characters, Bhagat and her team drafted a series of questions, including whether their protagonists would want to get married or have a child. When the independent and career-oriented Damini, played by Sayani Gupta, has an unplanned pregnancy, the writers were certain about things they'd avoid. "There'd be no argument on the moral and ethical aspect of abortion because we are pro-choice," says Bhagat. "It's why none of her three friends says it's wrong. They ask her, 'What do you want to do?'" Also, high on the priority list was to "stay away from *log kya kahenge* [what will people say]" mindset and "judgement from medical community".



"Unlike films, which need to cater to the widest mass possible, streaming shows don't have to. There's a bolder streak"

SONAM NAIR, Filmmaker

For Alankrita Shrivastava, creator of the Netflix series *Bombay Begums*, writing honestly about women entails exploring the "complicated relationship" they have with their bodies. "Something's always happening," she says. "It colours other areas of your life too." The fortysomething CEO character that Pooja Bhatt plays, for example, is in denial that she has hit menopause, afraid that she'll be seen as weak if she is open about its impact. "I wanted to break this idea that if you are in the menopausal state, you are not going to be sexually attractive," says Shrivastava.

Bombay Begums also looked at the distress women experience with their inability to conceive. The narrative arc was Shrivastava's way of examining the role "motherhood" has had in filmmaking. "I feel it is deified," she says. "I feel being the ideal mother in some way is linked to women and their bodies."

That women don't have agency over their bodies is a harsh reality even in developed countries like the US, where the Supreme Court this year overturned a 1973 landmark ruling on the constitutional right to abortion. It's a tricky topic in Indian cinema, too, with recent mainstream films like *Good Newwz* (2019) and *Mimi* (2021) depicting an anti-abortion stance. Streaming allows women to present a differing, non-judgemental take. ■